

The Question

How does the salient promise of future firearm regulation affect demand for guns? And, how much of this is explained by buying guns sooner vs. buying more guns overall?

How we answer it

In 2022, firearm access appeared on ballots in a public referendum in Oregon (“Measure 114”). We use data on the number of firearm-related background checks, collected through the FBI’s NICS system, to compare how Oregon’s background check rates changed compared to other states before and after the election. Measure 114 narrowly passed, was scheduled to be implemented one month later, but was halted by judicial stay. By extending the analysis period into the year after the stay, we can evaluate how much of the anticipatory increase in firearm demand is offset by later reductions in purchasing. This allows us to separate how much of the demand increase is due to new purchases that wouldn’t have occurred without Measure 114 versus normal demand that was pushed forward in time to avoid buying under the new regulations.

What we find

Policy anticipation increased firearm demand substantially, with the biggest increases taking place after the results of the election were known. Once the policy was halted, demand returned to approximately normal levels – this means most of the increases came from new demand rather than temporal displacement. In total, Oregon passing but not enacting Measure 114 resulted in an about 60,000 more firearms in circulation than predicted if Measure 114 had never appeared on the ballot.